officers is a must.

What does the general trend in Maoist violence in the last few years reveal? It is true that Chhattisgarh has registered a drop in attacks, but there has also been a corresponding drop in operations by forces. The security establishment also cites the expansion of security personnel camps in Sukma and Bijapur districts, in territories hitherto considered to be under Maoist control. The road from Dantewada to Aranpur has more than half a dozen security camps and the Aranpur police station is located barely a kilometer from the blast site, which itself is on a state highway. All these factors suggest the Maoists have the capacity to regroup and attack.

"We will intensify the fight against Maoists. This fight is in its last stages. Around 75 security camps have been set up in core Maoist areas. Development work has led to better access to core Maoist areas by security personnel," said Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel, while speaking to the media at a wreath-laying ceremony for the martyred personnel at Dantewada. Baghel added that while earlier Maoists attacked security camps, security forces are now taking the fight to the Maoists in their jungle bastions.

However, the BJP describes Baghel's statement as an "unfortunate" bit of whitewashing. "There was a time when people lived in fear of Maoists both in the Bastar and Surguja divisions, but the previous government had changed things in favour of civilians," says former CM Raman Singh. Elections are due in the state at the end of the year, so his claim to have cleared at least north Chhattisgarh (that is, Surguja) of the Maoist problem has self-evident propaganda value.

The last major incident involving the loss of lives of security personnel in Dantewada was in April 2019, in the run-up to the Lok Sabha elections, when BJP MLA Bhima Mandavi was killed in an IED blast. The latest attack clearly shows that in the fight against Maoism, security forces can only lower their guard at their own, great peril. ■

UP CIVIC POLLS

MAYA LOBS A GOOGLY

By Prashant Srivastava

On April 24, when Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar came to meet Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav in Lucknow as part of his efforts to push for Opposition unity, he did not meet Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) supremo Mayawati. Since meeting one former CM of Uttar Pradesh and not the other seemed to leave an obvious gap in his quest, journalists quizzed Nitish about it, but he chose to remain silent. Sources close to them claim that it was in fact 'Behanji', as the BSP chief is popularly known, who was reluctant to meet the Bihar CM.

Mayawati's strategy—more of a dilemma, in this case—is now out in the open. She cannot be seen standing with a united Opposition that has the SP as its key constituent at a time her party is eyeing the latter's key voter base to turn its own electoral fortunes. The SP counts Muslims, who comprise nearly 20 per cent of the state's population, as a core support group besides its natural Yadav base. And the BSP wants to spoil this delicate equation: it has fielded 11 Muslim mayoral candidates out of the 17 who are contesting the two-phase municipal corporation elections (May 4 and 11) in the state.

The BSP chief, who earlier unsuccessfully tried to forge a Dalit-Brahmin unity, claims that leaders

TOUCHING BASE ⌄
Mayawati at an Ambedkar Jayanti event in Lucknow, April 14

ANI

